transits of the HMS *Queen Elizabeth* aircraft carrier through the South and East China Seas would be postponed.

VII. The Lessons

Almost immediately after the announcement of the permanent ceasefire, analysts in the United States began debating the lessons of the war. While few interpretations were universally accepted, several key insights were generally seen as correct.

First, the origins of the war were years in the making. While historians cautioned against assuming that war was inevitable, or that the United States and China were fated to fight, observers agreed that years of deteriorating relations were a precondition to war. As suspicion grew in each country about the other, as working relations became more strained and formal, as the two eyed each other as the major threat each faced, both Washington and Beijing gave up on attempting to establish mechanisms to resolve the growing differences between them. Instead, each increasingly sought to justify actions that increased tensions and suspicion.

American analysts, however, were largely united in seeing China as the aggressor in the years leading up to the war. While the goal of US policy toward China since the 1970s had been to integrate it into the global economic and political system, Beijing increasingly chafed at what it considered to be restrictions on its freedom of action outside its borders. Instead of gaining confidence in dealing with the world, Chinese leaders, and especially Xi Jinping, saw enemies all around China; indeed, as US observers pointed out, in the years before the war, China had disputes with almost all of its neighbors, particularly maritime ones in the East and South China Seas. It was China, moreover, that built up a military designed to target US strengths in the region, precisely at the time when Washington was eager to make China the de facto number two in the global hierarchy. Finally, it was Beijing that intimidated and harassed its neighbors, threatened